

Arthropods

All arthropods have jointed legs and an external case, or exoskeleton. They form an enormous group of invertebrates, dominated by insects, but also including a huge variety of other animals on land and in water.

Crustaceans

Ranging from bulky lobsters to tiny water fleas, crustaceans live mainly in water. Their exoskeleton is often reinforced with calcium, forming a hard crust.



Lobsters use powerful claws to crack open mollusks on the seabed.



Crabs scavenge the shore and seabed with their two pincers. Their tails are tucked underneath their broad shells, or carapaces.



Krill form immense swarms in the open ocean. These shrimplike filter-feeders are a key food for baleen whales.



Barnacles spend their adult lives stuck to rocks or floating objects. They filter-feed with limbs protruding from their hard cases.



Water fleas swim by flicking branched antennae. They are tiny filter-feeders that are very common in freshwater.



Land-dwelling woodlice have domed bodies and seven pairs of legs. They feed on plant remains.



A horseshoe crab has a hinge between its rounded carapace and its abdomen.

Horseshoe crabs

Despite their name, horseshoe crabs are more closely related to spiders than to crabs. These armored arthropods have five pairs of walking legs hidden by a shield, or carapace. They eat animals, using pincers to pluck them from the seabed. There are just four living species.

Arachnids

Living mainly on land, arachnids usually have four pairs of legs. Most are carnivorous, and many have venomous bites or stings. Spiders make up the largest single group of arachnids, followed by mites and ticks.



Ground-dwelling predators, scorpions are armed with pincers and venomous stings.



Unlike true spiders, sun-spiders lack poison, so they use powerful pincers to kill and chew up their prey.



Orb-web spiders weave flat, spiral webs. Some species have spines and vivid warning colors.